

symptoms, observe the emotions and attitudes. If one insists on the presence of ghosts and spirits one cannot speak of therapeutics.”

Foundation of Major Herbal Traditions 300 BCE–600 CE

Trade between Europe, the Middle East, India, and Asia was already well under way by the 2nd century BCE, and trade routes became established for many medicinal and culinary herbs. Cloves (*Eugenia caryophyllata*, p. 97), for example, which are native to the Philippines and the Molucca Islands near New Guinea, were imported into China in the 3rd century BCE, and first arrived in Egypt around 176 CE. As the centuries passed, the popularity of cloves grew, and by the 8th century CE, their strong aromatic flavor and powerfully antiseptic and analgesic properties were familiar throughout most of Europe.



Galen's "four humors," which he believed made up the human constitution.

As trade and interest in herbal medicines and spices flourished, various writers tried to make systematic records of plants with a known medicinal action and record their properties. In China, the *Divine Husbandman's Classic* (*Shen'ong Bencaojing*), written in the 1st century CE, has 364 entries, of which 252 are herbal medicines, including bupleurum (*Bupleurum chinense*, p. 72), coltsfoot (*Tussilago farfara*,

p. 278), and gan cao (*Glycyrrhiza uralensis*). This Daoist text laid the foundations for the continuous development and refinement of Chinese herbal medicine up to the present day.

In Europe, a 1st-century CE Greek physician named Dioscorides wrote the first European herbal, *De Materia Medica*. His intention was to produce an accurate and authoritative work on herbal medicines, and in this he was dramatically successful. Among the many plants mentioned are juniper (*Juniperus communis*, p. 224), elm (*Ulmus carpinifolia*), peony (*Paeonia officinalis*, p. 243), and burdock (*Arctium lappa*, p. 65). The text, listing about 600 herbs in all, was to have an astonishing influence on Western medicine, being the principal reference used in Europe until the 17th century. It was translated into languages as varied as Anglo-Saxon, Persian, and Hebrew. In 512 CE, *De Materia Medica* became the first herbal to feature pictures of the plants discussed. Made for Juliana Arnicia, the daughter of the Roman emperor Flavius Avicius Olybrius, it contained nearly 400 full-page color illustrations.



Frontispiece decoration for the first illustrated herbal, Dioscorides' *De Materia Medica*, produced in Constantinople in 512 CE.

Galen (131–200 CE), physician to the Roman emperor Marcus Aurelius, had an equally profound influence on the development of herbal medicine. Galen drew inspiration from Hippocrates and based his theories on the “theory of the four humors” (see p. 32). His ideas shaped and, some would say, distorted medical practice for the next 1,400 years.

In India and in China, elaborate medical systems somewhat resembling the theory of the four humors developed (see pp. 36–38 and pp. 40–41 respectively) that have endured to the present day.

Though European, Indian, and Chinese systems differ widely, they all consider that imbalance within the constituent elements of the body is the cause of illness, and that the aim of the healer is to restore balance, often with the aid of herbal remedies.

Folk Healing in the Middle Ages

The theories of Galenic, Ayurvedic (Indian), and Chinese traditional medicine, however, would have meant practically nothing to most of the world's population. As is still the case today for some indigenous peoples who have little access to conventional medicines, in the past most villages and communities relied on the services of local “wise” men and women for medical treatment. These healers were almost certainly ignorant of the conventions of scholastic medicine, yet through apprenticeship and practice in treating illness, attending childbirth, and making use of locally growing herbs as a natural pharmacy, they developed a high level of practical medical knowledge.